

01

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

James, Otto, Advaita, Radhakrishnan, sacred/holy, prayer/worship, public discourse and veridicality are CORE PAPER II.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Phenomenology–object–warrant separation, comparison and graded verdict are CORE ANSWER.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not fill answers with brain-region catalogues, mystical case lists or claims that ineffability makes experience unintelligible.

ANSWER LINE: [FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

02

Current scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Fact: A 2025 Frontiers in Neuroscience review described neuroscience of religion as the study of correlations between brain functions and religious practices, beliefs and experiences, while emphasizing methodological and definitional limitations.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ Inference: Neural mediation does not by itself prove either veridicality or illusion.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It explains a mechanism or correlate; the philosophical question of the experience's object and warrant remains open.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ Inference: Neural mediation does not by itself prove either veridicality or illusion.

ANSWER LINE: □ Fact: A 2025 Frontiers in Neuroscience review described neuroscience of religion as the study of correlations between brain functions and religious practices, beliefs and experiences, while emphasizing methodological and definitional limitations.

03

Visual gateway — ask three questions in order

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Recommended opening definition: Religious experience is an experience interpreted as disclosing or relating the subject to an ultimate, sacred or divine reality.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Recommended opening definition: Mystical experience is a mode of religious experience marked, for William James, primarily by ineffability and noetic quality.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Core argument/criticism: Unlike episodic subject-object encounter, non-dual realisation claims to dissolve the distinction between knower and known and to become stable knowledge.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Equally, conceptual or neural mediation does not automatically make it fabricated.

ANSWER LINE: Master rule: A vivid or transformative experience can be psychologically real without its interpretation being automatically true.